

## Great Stupa, Sanchi

**Location** Sanchi, India

The Great Stupa at Sanchi was commissioned by the Mauryan king Ashoka in the 3rd century BCE. The unadorned, hemispherical brick burial mound housed a relic chamber thought to contain the Buddha's ashes. Substantially embellished over the centuries, it is one of Buddhism's most treasured monuments—for its distinctive art and architecture, as well as its sacred significance. By the 1st century BCE, its dome had been flattened slightly and its size increased to around 121 ft (37 m) wide and 56 ft (17 m) high. It was covered with stone slabs and encircled by a railing and a low outer wall. Four spectacular *toranas* (ceremonial gateways)

were also added, featuring statues and exquisite relief carvings that include fertility deities, auspicious symbols, and scenes from the Buddha's life.

## Ise Shrine

**Location** Ise, Japan

The Grand Shrine at Ise (formerly Uji-Yamada), in Mie prefecture, dates from the 3rd or 4th century CE and is the Shinto religion's most sacred shrine complex. Its many buildings are divided into two areas: an outer shrine, dedicated to Toyuke, the food goddess; and an inner shrine—the site's oldest and holiest place—dedicated to Amaterasu, the Sun goddess. The Ise Shrine is distinguished for its simplicity and harmony. Its buildings, made from thatch and

unpainted cypress, are raised about 7 ft (2 m) off the ground on posts. Every 20 years since the 8th century, the buildings have been demolished and replaced by exact replicas; this is thought to revitalize the site and the deities themselves.

## Lingyin Temple

**Location** Hangzhou, China

One of the oldest, largest, and most notable of China's ancient Buddhist temples, the Lingyin Temple, also known as the Temple of Souls, was

constructed during the Eastern Jin dynasty (317–420 CE). It was significantly embellished in later dynasties, particularly in the 10th century, when it is said to have housed more than 3,000 monks. The site's numerous palaces, halls, pavilions, and grottoes include striking examples of Buddhist art and architecture. Notable are the elegant double-eaved Hall of the Heavenly Kings, with its paintings of dragons and phoenixes, and the 112-ft- (34-m-) high Hall of the Great Hero, with a huge statue of Sakyamuni Buddha carved from camphor wood and coated in gold leaf.

▼ TORANA AT THE GREAT STUPA AT SANCHI

